

Pulakeshin II

Pulakeshin II (c. 610–642 CE) was the preeminent ruler of the Western Chalukya dynasty, based at [Badami](#) (ancient Vatapi) in present-day [Karnataka, India](#), who transformed a regional kingdom into a vast Deccan empire through military conquests and strategic alliances.^{[1][2]} Born as the son of King Kirtivarman I, Pulakeshin II ascended the throne in 610 CE after overthrowing his uncle [Mangalesha](#), who had seized power following his father's death.^[3] His reign marked the zenith of Chalukya power, with early campaigns securing victories over neighboring kingdoms such as the Kadambas and Gangas in the south.^[4] By around 624 CE, he conquered the [Vengi](#) region from the Vishnukundins and installed his brother [Kubja Vishnuvardhana](#) as [viceroy](#), thereby founding the Eastern Chalukya branch that would endure for centuries.^[3] Pulakeshin II's most celebrated achievement was his repulsion of the expansionist northern emperor Harshavardhana in a decisive battle near the Narmada River, dated variously between 618 and 630 CE, which halted Harsha's southward ambitions and established Chalukya dominance over much of central and southern India from coast to coast.^{[1][5][6]} The Aihole inscription of 634–635 CE, composed by his court poet Ravikirti in ornate Sanskrit, eulogizes these triumphs and traces the Chalukya genealogy back to their mythical origins, while also dating the Mahabharata war to approximately 3137 BCE.^[7] His diplomatic outreach included exchanges with the Persian emperor Khosrow II and the Chinese Tang court, as noted by the traveler Xuanzang, underscoring the Chalukyas' role in pan-Asian networks.^[8] Despite these successes, Pulakeshin II's empire faced relentless pressure from the Pallavas of Kanchi, culminating in the sack of Vatapi by [Narasimhavarman I](#) in 642 CE, shortly after the king's [death](#), which temporarily diminished Chalukya influence.^[1] His legacy endures as a symbol of Deccan resilience, patronizing [Shaivism](#), [Jainism](#), and temple architecture at sites like [Aihole](#), [Pattadakal](#), and [Badami](#), which later earned [UNESCO](#) recognition for their Vesara-style innovations.^[9]

Personal Background

Names and Titles

Pulakeshin II's [birth name](#) was Ereya, a pre-coronation designation recorded in Chalukya records such as the Peddavaduguru inscription, where he is referred to as Ereyatiyadigal. Upon ascending the throne in 610 CE, he adopted the coronation name Pulakeshin, the second ruler to bear this title in the dynasty, symbolizing valor and prowess as "pulaka" denotes the horripilation or thrill induced by heroic deeds or divine inspiration in [Sanskrit](#) nomenclature. This [naming convention](#) aligns with Chalukya traditions, where royal names often evoked attributes of strength and divine favor to legitimize rule.^{[10][11]} The king employed several grand titles that underscored his

imperial authority and military achievements, including Satyashraya ("resort to truth"), signifying unwavering adherence to [dharma](#) and justice; Prithvivallabha ("beloved of the earth"), a common epithet for sovereigns claiming universal dominion; Dakshinapathapala ("guardian of the south"), highlighting his role as protector of the southern regions; and Paramesvara ("supreme lord"), denoting supreme divine kingship. These titles, rooted in [Sanskrit](#) poetic and religious traditions, collectively portrayed Pulakeshin II as a divinely ordained [ruler](#) whose prowess extended over vast territories, blending martial valor with moral and cosmic legitimacy. In the renowned [Aihole inscription](#) dated 634–635 CE, composed by his court poet Ravikirti and engraved at the Meguti temple, Pulakeshin II is eulogized with these titles and self-described as the "lord of the [south](#)" (Dakshinapati), emphasizing his unchallenged sovereignty over peninsular [India](#). The inscription further celebrates him as the conqueror of the "three Maharashtrakas," referring to victories over regional powers in [Maharashtra](#), thereby reinforcing the symbolic weight of his titles as emblems of territorial expansion and unyielding power. Etymologically, such epithets drew from Vedic and Puranic ideals of kingship, where rulers were likened to guardians of cosmic order, with "[south](#)" symbolizing the fertile and strategic [Deccan plateau](#) under Chalukya control.

Early Life and Family

Pulakeshin II, originally named Ereyya, was born circa 590 CE as the eldest son of Chalukya king Kirtivarman I and a princess from the Sendraka family.

The [Chiplun](#) copper-plate grant of his reign identifies his maternal uncle as Sritvallabha Senanandaraja, a Sendraka ruler and [vassal](#), confirming the familial ties to this western Deccan lineage.^[12] Kirtivarman I's [death](#) in 597 CE left the throne to his minor son, prompting Kirtivarman's brother [Mangalesha](#) to assume regency. Raised in the Chalukya capital of Vatapi (modern [Badami](#)), Pulakeshin received a princely [education](#) suited to the dynasty's martial and administrative traditions, including training in warfare and governance amid the Shaivite religious milieu that defined Chalukya patronage.^[13] His family included a younger brother, Kubja Vishnuvardhana, whom he later appointed [viceroy](#) in the eastern territories, laying the foundation for the Eastern Chalukya [branch](#). References to other potential siblings, such as Adityavarman, remain ambiguous in the records, possibly indicating junior kin within the extended royal household.^[13] The regency under [Mangalesha](#) (597–610 CE) was marked by political instability, as the uncle suppressed multiple rebellions from disaffected feudatories and neighboring powers to stabilize the realm. The Mahakuta pillar inscription, issued in Mangalesha's fifth regnal year, boasts of his victories over the Kalachuri ruler Buddhiraja and other adversaries, including forces from [Vanga](#), [Anga](#), and Kalinga, underscoring the challenges faced in consolidating Chalukya authority during Pulakeshin's formative years.

Ascension to the Throne

Pulakeshin II ascended the throne in 610 CE following a successful [rebellion](#) against his uncle [Mangalesha](#), who had served as [regent](#) during Pulakeshin's minority after the [death](#) of his [father](#), Kirtivarman I. The conflict stemmed from Mangalesha's ambition to secure the succession for his own sons rather than allowing Pulakeshin, the rightful heir, to rule.^[14] To counter this usurpation, Pulakeshin organized resistance from the Svami temple at [Badami](#), rallying supporters and confronting [Mangalesha](#)'s forces. The [Aihole inscription](#), composed by the court poet Ravikirti in 634–635 CE, describes how Pulakeshin, protected by the goddess of victory, defeated and killed [Mangalesha](#) in the ensuing battle, thereby claiming the Chalukya throne. This victory at Elpattu Simbhige marked the end of the regency and Pulakeshin's emergence as the unchallenged ruler of the [Badami](#) Chalukyas.^[14] Following his triumph, Pulakeshin was crowned at Vatapi (modern [Badami](#)), the Chalukya capital, where he performed coronation rituals and adopted imperial titles such as Satyashraya ("the true refuge") and Parama-bhattaraka, signifying his sovereignty over vast territories. These titles, attested in contemporary inscriptions like the Hyderabad grant of 613 CE, underscored his legitimacy as an emperor on par with northern Indian rulers.

Military Conquests

Southern and Western Campaigns

Following his ascension, Pulakeshin II directed his initial military efforts toward subduing rebellious elements in the southern Deccan, targeting the remnants of the [Kadamba dynasty](#). Around 611–612 CE, he launched a campaign against Appayika and [Govinda](#), who were likely Kadamba chiefs asserting independence in the [Banavasi](#) region, and successfully recaptured the area, thereby restoring Chalukya authority over this former Kadamba stronghold.^[13] By approximately 615 CE, Pulakeshin II extended his dominance further south, subjugating the Alupas of [Banavasi](#) and the Gangas of Talakad through decisive military action that compelled them to submit and pay tribute. These victories, as recorded in the [Aihole inscription](#) composed by his court poet Ravikirti, underscored the king's prowess in quelling local dynasties and integrating them into the Chalukya sphere of influence.^[15] In parallel, between 610 and 615 CE, Pulakeshin II conquered the Mauryas of Konkana along the northern [Konkan](#) coast, securing Chalukya control over key maritime outlets. This campaign not only neutralized a potential threat from coastal powers but also facilitated access to trade routes vital for the empire's economy.^[15]^[13] These southern and western campaigns were strategically essential, as they granted the Chalukyas mastery over the [Western Ghats](#) passes and coastal

ports, enhancing defensive fortifications against incursions while bolstering economic prosperity through tribute and commerce. The [Aihole inscription](#) highlights how these conquests established Pulakeshin II as the paramount ruler of the Deccan, fostering regional stability under Chalukya hegemony.^[15]

Eastern Campaigns

Pulakeshin II launched military campaigns in the eastern Deccan around 620–624 CE, beginning with the subjugation of [Dakshina Kosala](#), where he defeated the Panduvamshi rulers and annexed the territory to expand Chalukya influence eastward. These victories were followed by incursions into parts of Kalinga, where local dynasties were compelled to submit, securing Chalukya control over strategic routes to the [Bay of Bengal](#). The [Aihole inscription](#) of 634–635 CE, composed by the poet Ravikirti, eulogizes these achievements, crediting Pulakeshin with overwhelming the kings of Kosala and Kalinga through decisive battles. Further advancing along the Andhra coast, Pulakeshin targeted the Vishnukundina dynasty, capturing key strongholds such as Pitakuru (modern Pithapuram) and other feudatories around 624 CE.^[7] This culminated in the overthrow of the Vishnukundina monarch, allowing Pulakeshin to seize the fertile Vengi region in the Godavari-Krishna delta.^[16] To consolidate his gains, he installed his younger brother, Kubja Vishnuvardhana, as the viceroy of Vengi, establishing a branch of Chalukya rule that marked the foundation of the Eastern Chalukya dynasty.^[16] Rather than direct administration, Pulakeshin II maintained control over these eastern territories through a [tribute](#) system, where [vassal](#) rulers paid regular homage and provided military support. Marital alliances further reinforced these ties, with inter-dynastic marriages ensuring loyalty among the subjugated elites and preventing rebellions in the region.

Diplomatic Interactions

Xuanzang's Visit

The Chinese Buddhist monk and traveler [Xuanzang](#) visited the Chalukya kingdom of Pulakeshin II in 641–642 CE, during his return journey from [Nalanda University](#) to [China](#). Traveling through [western India](#), Xuanzang arrived at the capital Vatapi (modern [Badami](#)), where he was warmly received by the king.^[17] Xuanzang noted the king's courtesy toward [Buddhism](#), despite his personal devotion to [Shaivism](#), as evidenced by the presence of numerous Hindu temples alongside Buddhist institutions.^[17] In his travelogue *Si-Yu-Ki*, [Xuanzang](#) depicted Vatapi as a thriving, fortified city nestled amid mountains and valleys, approximately 30 li (about 8 miles) in circumference, with fertile lands producing grains, sugarcane, and fruits. The city boasted around 100 Buddhist monasteries sheltering some 5,000 monks, practicing

both the Great Vehicle ([Mahayana](#)) and Small Vehicle ([Hinayana](#)). Additionally, there were about 100 non-Buddhist (Hindu) temples frequented by many heretics (Shaivite and other sectarians), underscoring the [religious pluralism](#) under Pulakeshin's rule. The traveler portrayed the king himself—referred to as Po-lo-ki-she—as a [Kshatriya](#) of "farsighted resource and astuteness who extends kindness to all", tall in stature like his subjects, who were described as honest yet hasty, with a dark complexion and rough manners.^[17] Xuanzang's firsthand observations serve as a crucial independent corroboration of Pulakeshin II's military achievements and tolerant religious policies, complementing and validating details from indigenous Indian inscriptions such as the Aihole prashasti, while providing unique qualitative insights into the empire's cultural and administrative vitality during this period.

Relations with Sassanid Persia

During the reign of Pulakeshin II (c. 610–642 CE), the Chalukya empire maintained diplomatic ties with the Sassanid Empire under [Khosrow II](#) (r. 590–628 CE), highlighted by an embassy sent from Vatapi to the Persian court in 625–626 CE. According to the Persian historian [al-Tabari](#), this mission occurred in the 36th year of Khosrow's reign and included valuable gifts and letters from Pulakeshin, referred to as "Furumisha" in the account, indicating friendly overtures possibly aimed at forging an alliance against shared adversaries such as the [Byzantine Empire](#) amid Khosrow's ongoing conflicts. A [fresco](#) in Ajanta Cave 1 depicts figures in Sasanian attire, interpreted as representing this embassy to Pulakeshin's court.^[18] These interactions facilitated robust maritime trade between the Deccan ports, particularly in the [Konkan](#) region under Chalukya control, and the [Persian Gulf](#). The Chalukyas exported commodities like spices, [cotton](#) textiles, and aromatic woods, which were highly valued in Sassanid markets, while importing Arabian horses essential for their [cavalry](#) and silver coins that circulated widely in Indian [commerce](#).^{[18][19]} Cultural exchanges emerged from these ties, with Zoroastrian traders from Persia likely frequenting Chalukya ports, contributing to limited but notable cross-cultural influences in [commerce](#) and [metallurgy](#), though no permanent communities are attested in the Deccan during this period. Such Sassanid stylistic influences later appeared in coinage of Chalukya successor states, like the Chalukyas of [Gujarat](#), featuring busts and fire altars. Additionally, the strategic maritime security ensured by Pulakeshin's western conquests supported the safe passage of these exchanges across the [Indian Ocean](#).^[19] The mutual interests extended to countering emerging threats in the [Indian Ocean](#), including potential disruptions from Arab maritime activities, as both empires sought to protect vital trade routes before the Sassanid collapse in the 630s CE. This bilateral engagement underscored the Chalukya empire's role in broader Eurasian networks during a pivotal [era](#).^[18]

Conflict with the Pallavas

Initial Engagements

The early phases of hostility between the Chalukya king Pulakeshin II and the Pallava ruler [Mahendravarman I](#) emerged around 620–630 CE, marked by Chalukya incursions into northern Pallava territories as part of broader efforts to expand southward. Pulakeshin's forces conducted raids targeting border regions, exploiting vulnerabilities in Pallava defenses following Mahendravarman's internal consolidations. These initial forays culminated in a significant Chalukya victory at the Battle of Pullalur in approximately 619 CE, where Pulakeshin decisively defeated the Pallava army led by [Mahendravarman I](#) near modern-day [Kanchipuram](#), allowing temporary Chalukya control over key northern outposts.^{[20][21]} A pivotal event in these engagements was the siege of [Kanchipuram](#), the Pallava capital, where Chalukya troops under Pulakeshin's direct command advanced to encircle the city after their success at Pullalur. Although the Chalukyas initially breached defenses and held the city briefly, they failed to consolidate their position due to swift Pallava reinforcements mobilized by [Mahendravarman I](#), who regrouped his forces to counter the invasion. This episode highlighted the logistical challenges of maintaining a distant occupation, as Chalukya supply lines stretched thin across the [Deccan plateau](#).^{[21][22]} The motivations driving these initial conflicts were rooted in strategic and economic imperatives, particularly the desire to control the fertile [Cauvery River delta](#), a vital agricultural heartland that promised substantial [revenue](#) from [rice](#) production and trade routes. Additionally, longstanding rivalry over succession claims in the [Vengi](#) region—where Pallava influence clashed with Chalukya ambitions, especially after Pulakeshin installed his brother [Vishnuvardhana](#) as viceroy following its conquest—intensified the border skirmishes. Vengi's position as a [buffer zone](#) between the two powers made it a flashpoint for asserting dominance.^{[23][22]} The outcomes of these early engagements included temporary truces brokered through diplomatic exchanges, allowing both sides to regroup amid mutual exhaustion, but they sowed seeds of deeper animosity. While Pulakeshin secured nominal tributes and border adjustments, the inability to hold [Kanchipuram](#) underscored the limits of Chalukya projection into core Pallava lands, escalating tensions toward more ambitious confrontations in subsequent years.^{[24][25]}

Defeat and Death

In 642 CE, [Narasimhavarman I](#) of the [Pallava dynasty](#) launched a major invasion against the Chalukya kingdom, seeking to avenge his father Mahendravarman's earlier defeat at the hands of Pulakeshin II. Following preliminary border conflicts, Narasimhavarman dispatched his general [Paranjothi](#) with a Pallava force to capture Vatapi, the Chalukya capital (modern [Badami](#)). Pulakeshin II mounted a counteroffensive but was decisively defeated in the ensuing battle on the outskirts of the city.^{[26][27]} Pulakeshin II was killed during the siege or combat, marking the end of his 32-year reign that began in 610 CE. The Pallavas sacked Vatapi, desecrating Chalukya temples and carrying off war booty, including, according to legend, the iconic Vatapi Ganapati idol. This victory is commemorated in a Pallava inscription at the Mallikarjuna Temple in Vatapi, dated to 642–643 CE, and another at the Teggina-Irappa Temple. Narasimhavarman adopted the title *Vatapikonda* ("Conqueror of Vatapi") to celebrate the triumph.^{[26][27][28]} The immediate aftermath saw a temporary Pallava occupation of Vatapi lasting until approximately 655 CE, during which the [Chalukya dynasty](#) faced near-collapse amid internal strife and loss of authority. The defeated Chalukyas were compelled to pay tribute to the Pallavas, weakening their hold over the Deccan region.^[26]

Governance and Cultural Patronage

Extent and Administration of the Empire

Pulakeshin II's empire at its [zenith](#) encompassed a vast territory across the [Deccan plateau](#), stretching from the [Narmada River](#) in the north to the [Kaveri River](#) in the south, and from the [Arabian Sea](#) in the west to the [Bay of Bengal](#) in the east.^[29] The core region lay in present-day [Karnataka](#), with [Badami](#) (ancient Vatapi) serving as the political and administrative center.^[30] This expansion was facilitated by military campaigns that incorporated vassal states, including regions in [Maharashtra](#) (such as the Lata and [Konkan](#) areas), Andhra (where the [Eastern Chalukyas](#) were established as feudatories under his brother [Vishnuvardhana](#)), and fringes of [Tamil Nadu](#) through conflicts with the Pallavas.^[2] The administrative structure was centralized at Vatapi, where the king wielded supreme authority, supported by a [council of ministers](#) and officials handling key functions.^[31] Prominent among these were the mahasandhi-vigrahikas, high-ranking ministers responsible for [diplomacy](#), [peace](#) negotiations, and [war](#) declarations, often mentioned in inscriptions as pivotal to foreign relations.^[32] The empire operated a feudal-like system, granting lands and autonomy to loyal feudatories such as the [Eastern Chalukyas](#) in [Vengi](#) and local chiefs in conquered

territories, ensuring tribute and military support while maintaining imperial oversight.^[29] Provincial divisions included *rashtras* (provinces) and *vishayas* (districts), governed by officials like the *rashtrakutas* and *vishayapatis*, who collected revenues and administered justice.^[31] Economically, the empire relied heavily on agrarian revenue from the fertile [Deccan plateau](#), where land taxes formed the primary income source, supplemented by tributes from vassals.^[33] Trade flourished through guilds headquartered near [Badami](#), which facilitated commerce in commodities such as grains, elephants, horses, and textiles across the Deccan and beyond to [Southeast Asia](#).^[34] The Chalukyas introduced standardized gold coins, including *varahas* bearing the dynastic boar emblem, to support transactions and assert economic sovereignty.^[29] Infrastructure developments bolstered governance and economy, with robust fortifications at [Badami](#) protecting the capital against invasions. Irrigation projects, including tanks and canals, enhanced agricultural productivity on the plateau, while road networks connected inland centers to coastal ports like [Banavasi](#) and [Sopara](#), aiding trade and troop movements.^[31]

Religious Policy

Pulakeshin II's religious policy was characterized by a primary affiliation with [Shaivism](#), marking a shift from the earlier [Vaishnavism](#) prevalent in the [Chalukya dynasty](#). Royal inscriptions from his reign, such as those invoking [Shiva](#) as the supreme deity, underscore his devout patronage of [Shaivism](#), positioning it as the dominant faith in the empire's official ideology.^[35] He performed traditional Vedic sacrifices, including the [Ashvamedha](#), to legitimize his rule and affirm Brahmanical orthodoxy, reflecting the integration of Vedic rituals into Shaivite practice. Despite this emphasis on Shaivism, Pulakeshin II demonstrated notable tolerance toward other faiths, granting lands and permissions to Buddhist *viharas* as observed by the Chinese traveler [Xuanzang](#), who noted over 100 Buddhist monasteries thriving in his kingdom without persecution.^[36] Similarly, his court poet Ravikirti, a Jain [scholar](#), constructed the Meguti temple at [Aihole](#) in 634 CE with royal endorsement, highlighting support for [Jainism](#) among diverse vassal communities.^[37] This policy of [religious pluralism](#) was strategically implemented through inscriptions that praised [Shiva](#) while allocating resources to Buddhist and Jaina institutions, fostering loyalty among the empire's heterogeneous subjects spanning various sects. No records indicate persecution of minority faiths, underscoring a pragmatic approach that balanced Shaivite devotion with inclusive governance.^[29]

Cultural and Architectural Contributions

Pulakeshin II's reign represented a pinnacle of Chalukya cultural [patronage](#), fostering advancements in [architecture](#) and [literature](#) that defined the Deccan region's artistic identity during the [7th century](#). He actively supported the construction and expansion of rock-cut temples, particularly the Shaivite caves at [Badami](#), which were excavated during his rule and feature intricate carvings of deities like [Shiva](#) in various forms, including [Tandava](#) and [Ardhanarishvara](#).[\[38\]](#) These temples, hewn directly from sandstone cliffs, demonstrate early mastery of rock-cut techniques and served as foundational examples of the [Vesara](#) architectural style, which harmoniously blended the curvilinear [shikhara](#) towers of northern Nagara traditions with the sturdy [vimana](#) pyramids and gopurams of southern Dravida influences.[\[39\]](#) The [Badami](#) complex, as the dynastic capital, thus became a showcase of Pulakeshin II's commitment to monumental stone [architecture](#) that integrated structural and sculptural elements. Equally significant was Pulakeshin II's role in developing the [Aihole](#) temple complex, where he commissioned the Meguti [Jain temple](#) in 634 CE, adorned with detailed friezes and pillars depicting Jina figures and floral motifs.[\[40\]](#) This site, often called the "cradle of Indian architecture," hosted over 120 temples and experimentation with hybrid forms, including early [chaitya](#) halls and square sanctums, under his oversight, further evolving the [Vesara](#) idiom as a precursor to later Hoysala and Rashtrakuta designs.[\[41\]](#) Rock-cut sculptures within these structures, such as those illustrating royal processions and battle scenes from Pulakeshin II's campaigns, highlighted artistic innovations in narrative relief work, using dynamic poses and symbolic [iconography](#) to glorify Chalukya sovereignty.[\[42\]](#) In literature, Pulakeshin II was a prominent patron of [Sanskrit](#) and emerging [Kannada](#) works, elevating courtly [poetry](#) to new heights. His most notable protégé was the Jain poet Ravikirti, who composed the renowned [Aihole](#) prasasti—a 56-verse [eulogy](#) inscribed on the Meguti temple wall—celebrating the king's conquests and comparing him to legendary figures like [Nahusha](#) and [Indra](#).[\[43\]](#) This inscription, rendered in chaste [Sanskrit](#) with old [Kannada](#) script, not only documented historical events but also exemplified the sophisticated *kavya* style, blending praise with literary flair.[\[10\]](#) By encouraging such compositions, Pulakeshin II promoted a bilingual literary culture that bridged classical [Sanskrit](#) traditions with regional vernacular expressions, influencing subsequent Deccan poets.[\[44\]](#) Pulakeshin II's sponsorship extended to performing arts, where royal endowments supported festivals, music, and dance performances in temple precincts and court assemblies, drawing on Shaivite and Jain themes to enrich communal rituals. These initiatives, rooted in his religious policy favoring Shaivism and Jainism, helped embed Chalukya aesthetics into enduring

Deccan cultural traditions, from rhythmic veena recitals to dramatic natya depictions of puranic tales.[\[41\]](#)

Sources and Legacy

Key Inscriptions and Records

The [Aihole inscription](#), dated to the [Saka](#) era year 556 corresponding to 634 CE, stands as the most prominent epigraphic record of Pulakeshin II's achievements. Composed in [Sanskrit](#) by his court [poet](#) Ravikirti, a Jain scholar, it is engraved on the outer wall of the Meguti temple in [Aihole](#) and serves as a [prashasti](#), or eulogistic poem, celebrating the king's [genealogy](#), military exploits, and royal titles. The text traces the Chalukya lineage from the dynasty's founder [Pulakeshin I](#) through Kirtivarman I and [Mangalesha](#) to Pulakeshin II, portraying the ruler as a paragon of valor who subdued northern powers like Harshavardhana of Kanauj, as well as southern adversaries including the Pallavas, Kadambas, Gangas, and Mauryas of the [Konkan](#). It highlights titles such as Satyashraya (the shelter of truth) and Prithvivallabha (beloved of the earth), emphasizing his imperial sovereignty and poetic prowess in comparing his deeds to epic heroes.[\[15\]](#) Additional inscriptions from Pulakeshin II's reign include rock edicts and pillar records at sites like [Badami](#) and Mahakuta, which document land grants and administrative decrees. The [Badami](#) cliff inscriptions, for instance, reference territorial expansions and royal benefactions. Copper plate grants, such as the Hyderabad plates (612 CE), Kandalgaon plates (614 CE), and Bijapur-Mumbai plates (619 CE) discovered in various regions, detail donations of villages and tax exemptions to [Brahmin](#) settlers and Jain monasteries, often invoking the king's overlordship and the empire's administrative hierarchy with officials like the mahasandhivigraha (minister for war and peace). These records, typically in [Sanskrit](#) with some [Kannada](#) influences, provide granular evidence of fiscal policies and feudal obligations during his rule from circa 610 to 642 CE. The Bijapur-Mumbai plates specifically record his victory over Harshavardhana, corroborating the [Aihole inscription](#). Numismatic sources complement these epigraphs, with gold coins issued under Pulakeshin II featuring the dynastic boar ([varaha](#)) emblem and inscribed with legends bearing his titles like Sri-Prithvivallabha. These pagodas, among the earliest standardized gold issues in peninsular [India](#), were punch-marked with symbols such as the boar, temples, and lamps, reflecting [Gupta](#) influences in their style and high purity, and attesting to robust trade networks extending to Persia and [Southeast Asia](#). Their weight standards (around 4 grams) indicate [economic stability](#) and the monetization of the Deccan economy.[\[45\]](#) The authenticity and chronology of these sources are corroborated by external accounts, including the Chinese pilgrim Xuanzang's mid-7th-century travelogue, which describes a prosperous kingdom matching the inscriptional portrayal of Pulakeshin II's domain, and Sassanid Persian diplomatic correspondence alluding to

alliances against common threats. Scholarly consensus affirms the [Saka](#) dating system used in the records, though debates persist on precise [regnal years](#)—such as whether Pulakeshin II ascended in 609 or 610 CE—based on cross-referencing paleographic styles, regnal year notations in grants like the Kandalgaon plates (dated to his fifth year), and astronomical data embedded in the texts.[\[44\]](#)

Succession and Historical Significance

Following the death of Pulakeshin II in 642 CE amid the Pallava sack of Vatapi (modern [Badami](#)), the [Chalukya dynasty](#) plunged into a [succession crisis](#) marked by internal divisions and foreign occupation. The capital fell under Pallava control, creating a [power vacuum](#) that persisted for roughly thirteen years, during which Pulakeshin's elder sons Adityavarman and Chandraditya briefly held sway but failed to consolidate authority amid ongoing threats. Chandraditya, ruling circa 646–649 CE, died young, leaving his wife Vijaya-Bhattarika to serve as [regent](#) for their minor son until around 655 CE; her inscriptions at Nerur and Kochre affirm her administrative role in maintaining Chalukya continuity during this turbulent [interregnum](#).[\[46\]](#) By 655 CE, [Vikramaditya I](#), Pulakeshin II's third son, emerged to restore the dynasty, leveraging alliances such as with his maternal grandfather, Ganga king [Durvinita](#), to drive out the Pallavas and reclaim Vatapi. This reconquest not only ended the occupation but also unified fractured territories, reasserting Chalukya hegemony across the Deccan; the brief regency period saw limited involvement from the line of Pulakeshin's brother Kubja Vishnuvardhana, whose Eastern Chalukya branch in [Vengi](#) provided peripheral support without direct control. Vikramaditya's success marked the dynasty's revival, though the crisis exposed vulnerabilities that later contributed to its eventual decline.[\[47\]](#) Pulakeshin II's historical significance lies in transforming the Chalukya kingdom into a Deccan powerhouse that served as a bulwark against northern imperial ambitions, exemplified by his 618 CE victory over Harshavardhana at the [Narmada River](#), which halted northern incursions and preserved southern autonomy. His expansive campaigns established a vast empire spanning from the [Arabian Sea](#) to the [Bay of Bengal](#), fostering a tripartite political framework in [south India](#) among the Chalukyas, Pallavas, and nascent Chola influences that defined regional rivalries and alliances for over two centuries. This balance of power elevated the Deccan from peripheral status to a central arena of Indian geopolitics, influencing [trade](#) routes and cultural exchanges across the subcontinent.[\[48\]](#) As an enduring symbol of southern [independence](#), Pulakeshin II's legacy underscores Deccan resilience, with modern [historiography](#) post-2000 increasingly viewing him as an empire-builder who unified diverse polities through innovative [governance](#). Scholarly analyses highlight his economic contributions, including the promotion of overseas [commerce](#) via ports like [Banavasi](#) and the issuance of coinage that spurred monetization and agricultural expansion, laying foundations for sustained prosperity in the region. Recent

archaeological discoveries, such as the 2024 unearthing of two 1,300-year-old Badami Chalukya temples and a label inscription in Mudimanikyam village, [Telangana](#) (as of February 2024), along with temple inscriptions and sculptural depictions at sites like [Aihole](#) and [Badami](#), illuminate the dynasty's architectural and cultural reach, including gender dynamics in the Chalukya [court](#) revealing women's influential roles as patrons, regents, and scholars—exemplified by figures like Vijaya-Bhattacharika—beyond traditional domestic confines.[\[49\]](#)[\[48\]](#)[\[50\]](#)[\[51\]](#)